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Myanmar 1962–1988: The Dictatorship of Ne Win

In the early morning hours of March 2, 1962, mechanized units of the Burmese military moved into Rangoon and secured control of all governmental structures, including the courts, legislative buildings, the airport, telegraph office, and police stations. Key leaders of the government, including Prime Minister U Nu, were arrested, along with multiple government ministers and the chief justice of the Supreme Court. Included in the round up were Shan, Kachin, Kayak, and Karen leaders. For the most part, the coup d'état was bloodless and efficient.

The rationale behind the action was the deteriorating condition of the union, according to Ne Win. The parliament was disbanded and the constitution suspended. The Revolutionary Council was quickly assembled within 24 hours following the coup. Members of the council were connected to Ne Win as far back as the anticolonial struggle of the 1930s–1940s. The council included Aung Gyi, Tin Pe, San Yu, and Sein Win. Ne Win was named minister of defense, finance, and revenue. Furthermore, he became president of the republics. No mention was made about future elections.

The federalism dilemma, especially in regard to the Shan states, was the decisive issue that destroyed Burmese democracy. In critiquing the problems of the U Nu regime, the Revolutionary Council stressed multiple issues. Projects that did not directly impact the population were scrapped. For example, the new national theater was demolished and renovations to the parliament building were stopped. Emphasis was given to the development of agricultural infrastructure, such as fertilizer, water pipes, and insecticides. The religion issue so prominent during the latter U Nu years was abandoned in place of more freedom of religion and religious